

The Cardinal's Promise

NOTES FOR SCOTT · AUGUST 2026 · ~57,000 WORDS

Scott — the copy you've been working from is a few weeks old. Here's what moved since, so you're not chasing things I already caught.

What changed

- The ending. The book was closing five separate times after the Epilogue. Two of those sections are gone — the back matter went from 1,630 words to 768.
- Chapter 26 came down 470 words, scenes kept and connective tissue cut. Chapter 28 is now "The Detour." Two of the five *Drives* are gone, and "showing up" went from 62 uses to 41.
- Two contradictions: I'd told the first pill twice as two different first times, and Lou's age when he met my mother didn't match the dedication.

Your note

You said the book isn't about Lou, it's about recovery. You're right and I won't argue it. But the recovery doesn't stand up without him in it, so instead of making the case, here are the moments I mean:

- I chose him back. I was eight, they were changing my name, and I asked if my middle name could be Lou. Nobody suggested it to me.
- The night before my sober date he took me to Carrabba's and sat across from me while I drank my last glass of wine. He didn't say a word against it.
- He flew to West Palm Beach and pulled me out of that apartment, then drove the U-Haul north himself. He was sixty-seven.
- On a drive to Ohio I told him thank you for saving my life. He said, you saved mine. We traded those two lines maybe ten more times over the years and his answer never changed.
- He stayed after the divorce, when nobody would have blamed him for going.

Recovery is what I went through. He's what carried it.

What I'm hoping you'll get into

- The chronology. You were right that it jumps. Part Four runs 2009, 2009, 2006, 2010, 2014, 2011, 2012, and I don't trust myself to reorder it.
- Chapter 19 is five people back to back and I think readers stall in there.
- I say in Chapter 3 that Lou had a temper and then never show it. Horacio gets to be difficult, and that's why he comes off more alive than my own father does.

One ask: go easy on the Epilogue. Everyone who's read it says that's where the book ends, and I think they're right.